

Pipeline and other companies were all hit by the “Internet Liberation Front” on Thanksgiving.

But all was not bad, as these troubled times gave rise to ethical hackers and some of the smartest brains ever to grace the information technology field.

Soon, common vulnerabilities in systems were well known and while the creators of these systems attempted to plug holes, the script kiddies played mischief. Hacking gave rise to Trojan Horses, these new tools didn’t require foreknowledge of how systems worked, just the skill to press buttons in the correct sequence. The first Trojan was discovered in 1998 and went by the infamous name “Back Orifice”. Back Orifice was a tool that allowed remote administration of any computer that it infected. With Back Orifice, people could take over remote computers, open any files, delete whatever they wished and just about do anything harmful they wished.

While viruses poured in, all was not well in the antivirus camp. In 1997 almost all antivirus vendors were fighting each other in court, or just making a noise about each other. McAfee’s “The Number One Choice Worldwide. No Wonder The Doctor’s Left Town” led to name calling with its biggest rival, Dr Solomon. McAfee was also in court with Trend Micro over the patent for e-mail data scanning.

Dr Solomon was accused of “cheating”, because its scanner supposedly shifted into “Advanced Mode” when it detected a virus, thus enabling it to catch a lot of other viruses that would otherwise be invisible under the “Normal Mode”. McAfee claimed that this was the reason that Dr Solomon was fast to scan uninfected disks, and caught more viruses in tests performed with virus collections—though we still fail to see how this was a “bad” feature for an antivirus to have. Symantec was also accusing McAfee of using Symantec code in McAfee products. Needless to say, there was a lot of squabbling.

However, the year ended on a noteworthy event—McAfee